

"the" & "a" Simplified Factor Table [日本語]

Quick Reference Guide

Factors	The	A, an	Examples
Focus of comment コメントの焦点	narrow focus 狭い焦点	broad focus 広い焦点	The: Please focus on the tunnel of light. A: France is a nation among many. Possessive: They are our friends.
Group size グループサイズ	small group 着くない	big group 思い	A: Please show him a painting. The: Please show him the Van Gogh.
Singular or Plural 単一/複数の	plural 複数の	single 単一	The: These are the three pens. A: This is a pen.
Number in existence いくつの	Only one exists (in the context) は1つのみ存在	Many exist (in the context) 多くが存在する	The: This is the Milky Way Galaxy. A: The is a grain of sand. Possessive: This is your island.
Specialness 特別な/特別ではありません	Very Special 特別な	Not Special 特別ではありません	The: Naoto Kan was the prime minister. A: This is a goldfish.
Mentioned already or not 前に述べた/ 前に言及されていない	already mentioned 前に述べた	not already mentioned 前に言及されていない	A: A team of researchers in Belarus... The: The researchers found that....
Countability 可算性	Uncountable 可算ません	Countable 数えられる	The: I'll have the red house wine, please. The: (specific) May I have the green cup? A: I'll have a cup. Silent "some": I'll have wine.

Table 1: Factors [For using "The" vs. "A" vs. "none" vs. "pronoun" vs. "possessive"]

The rule of the silent "some": *If you can say "some," then you can use no-word.* e.g. I am drinking water. = I am drinking **some** water.
The = "definate article," A,An = "indefinate article"